



**Asmaa Essakouti. *Realms of Strangers. Readers, Language, and Trickery in Ma-qāmāt al-Ḥarīrī*. Wiesbaden: Reichert Verlag. 2024. 202 pp. ISBN 978-3-7520-0793-0. € 69,00.**

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*Realms of Strangers. Readers, Language, and Trickery in Maqāmāt al-Ḥarīrī* by Asmaa Essakouti, postdoctoral researcher at the University of Münster, offers an innovative contribution to scholarship on the work of the Basran poet and philologist Abū Muḥammad al-Qāsim ibn ‘Alī al-Ḥarīrī (d. 516/1122). Published in 2024 by Reichert Verlag as the fiftieth volume in the series *Literaturen im Kontext, arabisch – persisch – türkisch*, the monograph stems from Essakouti’s PhD dissertation, providing a fresh critical perspective on the *Maqāmāt al-Ḥarīrī* – or *Ḥarīriyya* – through the lens of “strangeness” (ar. *ġarāba*).

The *maqāmāt* (“assemblies”) are fictional narratives in rhymed and rhythmic prose (ar. *sağ’*) featuring a roving trickster whose livelihood depends on his mastery of rhetoric (Drory 1998:507-8). The genre first appeared in the 4<sup>th</sup>/10<sup>th</sup> century with al-Ḥamadānī’s *Maqāmāt*, and achieved full prominence only a century later with the *Maqāmāt al-Ḥarīrī*. His brilliant rhetoric captivated the educated public, eclipsing his predecessor, until the advent of modern literary conventions, which radically altered the reception of the *Ḥarīriyya*.

The rupture between premodern and modern readerships represents a productive starting point for Essakouti’s study. She observes how the shift in literary taste affected the perception of al-Ḥarīrī’s work: traits once admired – ambiguity, playfulness, and humor – came to be dismissed as excessive ornamentation or symptoms of literary «decadence» (p. 2). Beginning with an external examination of the *Maqāmāt*, the author first considers its reception, production context, and existing scholarship, then turns inward to analyze the literary motifs and narratological features that shape the text. While previous scholars have focused almost exclusively on the *Ḥarīriyya*’s linguistic and stylistic peculiarities, this dual approach allows her to explore previously unexplored dimensions. The title *Realms of Strangers* is particularly revealing: it evokes the world inhabited by both the *Maqāmāt* and its protagonist, Abū Zayd al-Sarūġī, and captures the study’s central interpretive key – strangeness – conceived as the guiding thread that Essakouti traces through its different manifestations across the text.

The volume opens with an informative twenty-page introduction that supplies the reader with essential tools to approach al-Ḥarīrī’s collection and, more specifically, Essakouti’s analysis, disclosing its scope and aims. The book is organized in a tripartite structure modeled, as the author herself declares, on «al-Ḥarīrī’s symmetrical use of storytelling, language, and episodes» (p. 18). Each part, consisting of three chapters, focuses on a specific aspect of the work, proceeding from external to internal. A five-page conclusion is followed by an appendix that lists and summarizes the fifty *Maqāmāt*: as

al-Ḥarīrī provided his readers with appendices clarifying riddles and vocabulary (p. 19), Essakouti includes a practical tool for navigating the *Ḥarīriyya*'s dense and intricate corpus.

The first part, *The Readership of the Ḥarīriyya*, reconstructs the history of its reception from the 6<sup>th</sup>/12<sup>th</sup> century to the modern era, showing how the fascination with its eccentricity, so vivid among al-Ḥarīrī's contemporaries, gradually gave way to the criticisms of modern intellectuals. Whereas the former appreciated its linguistic and narrative complexity, acknowledging its ludic and performative function, the latter deemed the work obscure, morally ambiguous, and of little utility: fragmented into rigid categories and selectively translated in its less problematic parts, it came to epitomize «Oriental bad taste» within a distinctly Orientalist framework (pp. 41-50).

The second part of the volume, *Trading Gharīb in the Ḥarīriyya*, explores the first and most evident form of strangeness identified in the collection: the rare and strange lexicon (ar. *ḡarīb*). Through a meticulous lexical-semantic analysis, Essakouti investigates the construction of the *ḡarīb* within the premodern Arab-Islamic milieu and, by extension, within al-Ḥarīrī's *Maqāmāt*. Focusing on particularly illustrative episodes, she analyzes how the *ḡarīb* – made up of riddles, wordplay, technical terms, and Bedouin vocabulary – operates through the speech of the trickster al-Sarūḡī. Portrayed as a true medieval Arab *homo rhetoricus*, he embodies the very notion of linguistic strangeness, turning the *ḡarīb* into both a stylistic device and a defining feature of his character.

In the third part, *Being a Gharīb*, Essakouti highlights another form of strangeness: *ḡurba*. Drawing on its semantic field – estrangement, exile, the condition of living far from one's homeland (Wehr 1976:783) – the author explores the interplay between linguistic and human otherness in premodern *adab* ("literature"). A close reading of episodes distant within the work yet closely connected on a thematic and symbolic level reveals al-Sarūḡī's background and unique position: his wanderings are read as metaphors for displacement and identity, linking the *Ḥarīriyya* to broader discourses on estrangement in Arab culture. Compared to al-Ḥamadānī's trickster, Abū al-Faṭḥ al-Iskandarī, al-Sarūḡī is reinterpreted throughout his strangerhood as both a man of letters and a displaced human being shaped by loss and ambiguity.

Although her study relies on *Ḥarīriyya*'s printed editions rather than manuscripts, Essakouti compensates for this with a lucid and well-grounded interpretive framework. It benefits from her ability to draw on sources from diverse disciplines, linking them – naturally and seamlessly – to a literary text in order to reveal a hypothetical hidden meaning. These sources include commentaries, biographical dictionaries, poetic texts, *adab* anthologies, lexicographical works, and a rich corpus of translations and modern critical studies in Arabic, French, and English. Her methodology combines literary criticism, narratology, and discourse analysis with a sensitivity to reception theory, while maintaining a balance between textual and contextual perspectives.

The study's novelty lies in the recognition of the protagonist's inner dimension through his strangerhood, defined as much by his language as by his social and, above all, human experience. As Essakouti notes, « only a *ġarīb* (stranger) can provide the *ġarīb* (rare vocabulary) » (p. 14). Al-Sarūġi's condition thus becomes both the object and the method of analysis – a hermeneutic tool through which the author redefines al-Ḥarīrī's narratives as a complex reflection on alienation, performance, and fascination with the rare. In doing so, she challenges the modern critical tradition that dismissed al-Ḥarīrī's *Maqāmāt* as «a pale reflection of those of al-Ḥamaḍānī» (Margoliouth & Pellat 2012) and reopens a comparative perspective that allows it to be reconsidered on its own terms. Essakouti returns the *Ḥarīriyya* to its premodern audience – the only one truly capable of appreciating it in its entirety, or, more precisely, in its strangeness – while also opening it to a potential new readership (p. 19), one interested in exploring its depth. Clear, erudite, and elegantly argued, *Realms of Strangers* casts the *Ḥarīriyya* in a new light, offering a valuable contribution to scholarship on the *Maqāmāt* and inviting today's readers to rediscover the work.

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